

COUNTERINSURGENCY

COMBAT IN AFGHANISTAN

The soldiers of the International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) operating against Taliban insurgency in Afghanistan had access to the most advanced military technology available in the early 21st century. But as Operation Moshtarak showed in February 2010, this still left infantrymen vulnerable.

Operation Moshtarak was a large-scale offensive into a Taliban-controlled area of Helmand Province in southern Afghanistan. Some 15,000 American, British, Canadian, and Afghan army troops were sent in to wrest control of the area in order to disrupt poppy cultivation and drug-trafficking networks, and install government rule. The insurgents were hiding among the local population and occupying the towns of Marjah and Showal.

Equipped with the latest night-vision optics, the ISAF was able to launch the operation under cover of darkness. Small special forces units that had infiltrated the target area – British SAS and US Navy SEALs – called in strikes by Predator unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) and Apache attack helicopters against Taliban positions. About two hours before dawn, Super Stallion and Chinook helicopters, escorted by helicopter gunships, airlifted troops to landing sites near the target towns. The soldiers advanced with caution across ground scattered with improvised explosive devices (IEDs), the cause of two-thirds of ISAF casualties in Afghanistan. Using portable aluminium bridges, they were able to cross the numerous irrigation ditches without traversing existing bridges that would inevitably be mined. While the airlifted troops approached the Taliban-held towns, other US forces began advancing from their bases overland into Taliban territory. M1 Assault Breacher Vehicles led the way along the heavily mined and booby-trapped roads; occasionally line charges (rockets towing cables of plastic explosive) were fired ahead to blow up any concealed devices.

The opening day of the operation was impressively efficient and successful, with pockets of Taliban resistance smartly overcome. US Marines established themselves inside Marjah and British troops entered Showal. Most Taliban forces had probably left by this stage, but sufficient insurgents remained in the towns to pose a serious threat. The typical Taliban armoury of AK assault rifles, RPG-7 rocket-propelled grenade launchers, PK machine guns, and bolt-action sniper rifles was a match for ISAF infantry weapons in an environment that offered plentiful concealment.

WAR AMONGST THE PEOPLE

Clearing the town house by house was a demanding task. The obvious tactic for the Americans and British, eager to keep their own casualties low, was to identify the buildings occupied by Taliban elements and call in air strikes or use surface-to-surface missiles to destroy them. Modern guidance systems ensured that specific targets could be hit with a high degree of accuracy most of the time, but there was still a grave risk of politically undesirable civilian casualties. Indeed, on the second day of the operation, two missiles fired by an American High Mobility Artillery Rocket System (HIMARS) – a truck-mounted multiple rocket launcher – killed 12 Afghans in Marjah, including children.

Although the main towns were officially under Afghan government control within 12 days of the start of the operation, draining low-level combat continued, with sniper fire and IEDs imposing a steady toll on ISAF and Afghan soldiers. In time, the outcome would prove inconclusive.

